Chapter Sixty-Two

The Triumph of the Bruce

Between 1304 and 1314, Edward I subdues the Scots, Edward II flees from them, and Robert Bruce becomes their king

EIGHT YEARS of desperate fighting against the English had resulted in little gain for the Scots.

William Wallace had followed up his victory at Stirling Bridge with an invasion of England itself and had returned to Scotland loaded with plunder and glory. But the following year an English army crushed Wallace's men in the Forth valley near Falkirk, and Wallace was driven into hiding. Four more years of fighting yielded no real advantage for either side, and no single leader of the Scottish cause emerged. Edward, anticipating a victory yet to be won, awarded the title Prince of Wales to his oldest son, also named Edward; the first time an English heir apparent had claimed it.

In 1302 a brief peace had been declared. But nine months later, Edward invaded Scotland once more. Deprived of Wallace, deprived of French support, the Scots were defeated again and again. By Easter of 1304, Edward had fought his way up to Stirling Castle on the river Forth.

He planned the attack on the castle as a massive demonstration of English strength; he had commissioned a mammoth new trebuchet nicknamed the "War-wolf," and as the siege began five master carpenters and fifty craftsmen were still assembling it outside Stirling's walls. Prince Edward, just turned